

Formal Report on Practical Training CON2013X

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TERMS OF REFERENCE

This report has been prepared to fulfil the practical training requirements of CON2013X as prescribed by the Department of Construction Economics and Management at the University of Cape Town.

The report reflects on practical training undertaken with H&I Construction, a privately owned multi-disciplinary South African construction company operating across a range of sectors including roads and earthworks, civil and building construction, water infrastructure, mechanical and electrical works, and other major engineering projects. H&I has operated nationally since 1984 and delivers projects for both public and private sector clients.

The practical training was completed over two vacation periods between 23 June 2025 and 10 June 2026 and amounted to a total of 229 hours of supervised work experience. Although H&I operates across numerous construction disciplines, my placement was specifically within a project management team responsible for administering City of Cape Town maintenance and infrastructure contracts under the 34Q and 144Q term tenders.

The training was conducted primarily at Tygerberg Site Camp 2 and later at H&I's Durbanville Head Office. During this period, exposure was gained to project management, contract administration, quantity surveying, procurement processes, document control, project planning and site inspections. The practical training also provided opportunities to interact with project managers, quantity surveyors, engineers, site agents and other construction professionals involved in the delivery of municipal projects.

The purpose of this report is to document the practical experience obtained, reflect on the lessons learned, evaluate the development of professional and technical skills, and demonstrate how the experience contributed towards a broader understanding of the construction industry and the learning outcomes of the BSc Construction Studies programme.

SUMMARY

This report provides a reflection on the practical training undertaken with H&I Construction between 23 June 2025 and 10 June 2026, totalling 229 hours of supervised practical experience. The training was completed as part of the requirements for CON2013X across 3 vacation periods and provided exposure to the managerial, contractual and administrative aspects of the construction industry.

The practical training was conducted at Tygerberg Site Camp 2 and later at H&I's Durbanville Head Office. Throughout the training period, I worked alongside project managers, quantity surveyors, engineers and other construction professionals involved in the management and delivery of City of Cape Town maintenance and infrastructure projects under the 34Q and 144Q term tenders.

My responsibilities included assisting with workload planners, processing Purchase Orders, reviewing subcontractor quotations, compiling project documentation, preparing Purchase Order Alerts and Letters of Appointment, undertaking quantity measurements using drawings and digital measurement software, and assisting with project administration activities. In addition, I accompanied project managers and quantity surveyors on various site inspections where defects, workmanship standards, snag lists and practical completion requirements were assessed.

One of the most significant aspects of the training was gaining an understanding of how construction projects are managed beyond the physical work taking place on site. The experience highlighted the importance of contract administration, procurement processes, document control, financial management and communication in ensuring successful project delivery. It also demonstrated the role that quantity surveyors and project managers play in coordinating contractors, managing project costs and ensuring contractual obligations are met.

The practical training provided an opportunity to apply concepts learned through Construction Studies courses such as Construction Management, Measurement and Design Appraisal, Quantity Surveying and Business Law. It also contributed significantly to my professional development by improving my confidence, communication skills, attention to detail and understanding of the construction industry.

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Subject of and Motivation for Report

This report documents the practical training undertaken by Sage Agnew, a fourth-year BSc Construction Studies student at the University of Cape Town, during employment with H&I Construction in 2025 to 2026. The motivation for this report stems from the degree requirement to complete 480 hours of supervised practical experience within a built environment discipline. The report aims to demonstrate the integration of theoretical knowledge acquired throughout the students degree and to gain exposure of the practical realities of a professional construction environment.

1.2. Background to Report

H&I Construction is a national construction company that undertakes a wide range of projects across various sectors of the construction industry. Although the company is involved in large-scale civil engineering and building projects, my placement was specifically within a project management team responsible for administering City of Cape Town maintenance and infrastructure contracts under the 34Q and 144Q term tenders.

The practical training was conducted primarily at Tygerberg Site Camp 2 and later at H&I's Durbanville Head Office. Throughout the placement, I worked alongside project managers, quantity surveyors, engineers, site agents and other construction professionals responsible for the planning, administration and delivery of municipal projects. This environment provided valuable exposure to both office-based construction management functions and site-based inspection activities.

Construction Studies students enrolled at UCT, are required to complete practical training reports in accordance with the courses CON1007X, CON2013X, and CON3023X. Students are required to complete 480 hours of supervised employment experience within the built environment. The aim of this practical training is to supplement theoretical learning with practical exposure to construction and built environment contexts. This report, which will be submitted to and graded by the course convenor Karen Le Jeune, which documents the student's experience during the 2025 vacation periods with H&I Construction.

1.3 Objectives of Report

The objectives of this report are to:

- Document the daily activities and tasks undertaken during the practical training period.
- Provide a reflective analysis of the skills acquired, linking them to the BSc Construction Studies degree outcomes.
- Demonstrate an understanding of contract administration, project management, and quantity surveying principles within a corporate construction environment.
- Fulfil the assessment requirements for the course CON2013X.

1.4. Limitations and Scope of Report

The practical training consisted of 229 hours of supervised work experience completed over two vacation periods. The scope of the placement included project administration, workload planning, Purchase Order processing, contract documentation, quantity measurements, subcontractor quotation reviews, site inspections and quality control activities.

A limitation of the practical training was the relatively short duration of the vacation periods. Construction projects often span several months or years, making it difficult to observe every stage of the project lifecycle during a single training period. As a result, exposure was limited to specific project phases and activities taking place during the time of the placement. Despite this limitation, the variety of projects and responsibilities encountered provided valuable insight into the construction industry and the role of contractors within the built environment.

1.5. Plan of Development

The report begins with an overview of the practical training experience before presenting a reflective discussion of the lessons the student learned as well as technical observations and professional development achieved throughout the placement. Particular attention is given to project management, contract administration, quantity surveying, site inspections and the relationship between theoretical knowledge and industry practice.

1.6. Research Approach

The report is based primarily on observations made during the practical training period, discussions with construction professionals, project documentation reviewed during the placement and personal reflections recorded in the daily logbook. Additional information was obtained through company documentation, construction drawings, Bills of Quantities, workload planners and contractual records encountered during the training period.

2. REFLECTIVE ESSAY

2.1 From Site Labour to Construction Management: A Change in Perspective

My practical training at H&I Construction represented a significant shift from my previous experience in the construction industry. Prior to joining H&I, my practical exposure had primarily been through Feytcon Construction, where I worked as a labourer and was involved in activities such as paving, bricklaying, earthworks and other site-based operations. With this initial background in mind, I entered H&I expecting that most of my time would be spent on construction sites observing large projects and participating in physical construction activities.

My expectations were quickly challenged. Rather than being placed on a construction site full-time, I spent most of my practical training within a professional office environment alongside project managers, quantity surveyors and engineers. Initially, this came as a surprise. The image I had of construction was largely based on what happens physically on site, yet I quickly realised that a considerable amount of construction work takes place long before labour arrives on site and continues long after construction activities have commenced.

One of the biggest surprises during my practical training was the large volume of documentation required to manage construction projects effectively. Throughout the office there were shelves, files and folders containing Purchase Orders, subcontractor quotations, Bills of Quantities, workload schedules, contract documentation, safety records, Letters of Appointment and project correspondence. Before this experience, I had never fully appreciated the administrative effort required to deliver construction projects. It became clear that successful project delivery depends just as much on planning, communication and documentation as it does on physical construction work.

This experience broadened my understanding of the construction industry considerably. I began to recognise that project managers, quantity surveyors and engineers spend a significant portion of their time coordinating information, managing contracts, monitoring costs and communicating with clients and subcontractors. The practical training therefore provided a more complete picture of the industry and demonstrated how the contractual, financial and managerial aspects of construction are interconnected.

2.2. Working Within a Professional Environment

One of the most important adjustments I had to make during my practical training was adapting to a professional office environment. Unlike my previous site-based experience, where work was physically demanding and tasks were often visible and immediate, much of the work at H&I required concentration, organisation and attention to detail.

During the first few weeks, I placed significant pressure on myself to perform well. As a Construction Studies student and H&I bursary recipient, I felt that I should already possess a high level of competence. Whenever I was given a task, I wanted to complete it quickly and accurately so that I could take on additional responsibilities. Unfortunately, this mindset often worked against me. In my attempts to complete tasks independently, I sometimes overlooked important details or misunderstood instructions, resulting in errors that could have been avoided through communication.

Looking back, I realised that I had created an unrealistic expectation for myself. I believed that asking too many questions would make me appear inexperienced, incapable or weak. In reality, the opposite was true. My superiors consistently encouraged me to ask questions and reminded me that practical training is intended to be a learning experience. At some point in my training my superiors started feeling more like colleagues and over time, I became more comfortable seeking clarification and discussing challenges with the project managers, engineers and the quantity surveyors around me.

As my confidence improved I found myself becoming more involved in the workplace. By the end of the training period, I was actively requesting additional work once I had completed assigned tasks and regularly sought feedback on my performance. I no longer viewed questions as a sign of weakness but rather as an opportunity to learn. This shift in mindset was one of the most valuable personal lessons gained during the placement.

Another aspect of the professional environment that stood out to me was the competence of the individuals around me. The quantity surveyors demonstrated an exceptional ability to use Excel and other digital tools to process large volumes of information efficiently. The project managers displayed confidence when interacting with subcontractors, clients and consultants, particularly when discussing deadlines, defects and contractual responsibilities. Observing these professionals helped me appreciate the level of expertise required to manage construction projects successfully and provided a standard of professionalism that I hope to achieve in my future career.

2.3. Understanding Government Construction and Term Tenders

One of the most valuable aspects of my practical training was gaining exposure to the administration and management of municipal construction projects. Throughout my placement, I worked within a project management team responsible for administering City of Cape Town projects under the 34Q and 144Q term tenders. Prior to joining H&I, I had encountered concepts such as contracts, procurement and tendering primarily through lectures and tutorials. However, this practical experience provided an opportunity to observe how these systems operate within a real construction environment.

Through discussions with project managers and quantity surveyors, I learned that the City of Cape Town acts as the client for these contracts and appoints H&I through term tenders to carry out maintenance, repair and infrastructure works. The 34Q contract primarily relates to heritage building maintenance projects and typically requires the preparation of a Scope of Works and Bill of Quantities before work can proceed. The 144Q contract covers water and sanitation related works, including additions, alterations, repairs and maintenance activities. Understanding the distinction between these contracts helped me appreciate how construction work is organised, funded and administered within local government.

One of the concepts that became much clearer during my training was the relationship between tender rates, Bills of Quantities and subcontractor pricing. At university, the term "BOQ" was frequently discussed in theoretical contexts, but my understanding remained largely academic. At H&I, I was able to work directly with Bills of Quantities and compare subcontractor rates against H&I's tendered rates. This process demonstrated how contractors assess the financial viability of work packages and identify potential profit and loss items before appointing subcontractors. It also highlighted the importance of accurate pricing for cost control and to ensure profitability of construction projects.

Another important learning experience involved understanding the role of Purchase Orders within the construction industry. Before joining H&I, I had some exposure to Purchase Orders through my involvement as Food Representative in my first-year residence at UCT. When organising residence events, I would generate Purchase Orders for groceries and snacks, which were submitted to the university for approval before purchases could be made. During my practical training, I realised that the same principle applies within the construction industry, although on a significantly larger scale. At H&I, Purchase Orders issued by the City of Cape Town served as formal authorisation for work to proceed and confirmed that funding had been allocated for specific projects. Processing these documents helped me understand the relationship between procurement, budgeting and project delivery.

A particularly interesting aspect of the placement was observing the pressure created by the City of Cape Town's financial year-end. During my first week at H&I, many project managers were focused on achieving Practical Completion on their projects before the end of June. Initially, I did not fully understand why there was such urgency. However, through conversations with project managers and quantity surveyors, I learned that delays could have contractual and financial implications for both subcontractors and the main contractor. As the deadline approached, I observed an increase in communication between project teams, more frequent site visits and greater emphasis on obtaining approvals, sign-offs and completion certificates.

This experience demonstrated that project deadlines are not determined solely by construction activities on site. Financial, contractual and administrative requirements also influence project delivery. Seeing the impact of the City of Cape Town's municipal financial year-End on construction projects, helped me appreciate the importance of planning, scheduling and stakeholder management. It also reinforced concepts studied in Construction Management modules regarding programme control, practical completion and contractual obligations.

Perhaps the most significant lesson from this aspect of the training was understanding that construction projects operate within a broader organisational and financial framework. Successful project delivery depends not only on technical construction work but also on effective contract administration, financial management and communication between the various stakeholders involved in the project.

2.4. Contract Administration and Quantity Surveying Exposure

Concepts such as Bills of Quantities, procurement, tendering and contract administration had been introduced in class, I had never seen how these processes were managed within an active construction environment.

One of my primary responsibilities was assisting with the maintenance and updating of workload planners used by project managers. These workload planners served as work diary for Project manager which contained their individual project information and it contained records relating to project status, Purchase Orders, contract details, subcontractor quotations, H&I quotations, Letters of Appointment and supporting contractual documentation. My role involved reviewing and updating project information, organising documentation and ensuring that records relating to completed and ongoing projects were correctly maintained. Through this process, I developed a much greater appreciation for the importance of document control and information management within construction projects.

Initially, I found these workload planners difficult to understand, it overwhelmed me. There were numerous documents associated with each project, and I often struggled to identify which information was relevant and where it should be recorded. Knowing this now though one of my biggest mistakes was trying to solve every problem independently. I spent a considerable load of time attempting to understand spreadsheets, contract information and pricing structures without asking for assistance. This often resulted in mistakes and unnecessary delays but as the placement progressed, I became more comfortable approaching quantity surveyors and project managers for guidance. Doing so not only improved the quality of my work but also significantly increased my confidence in completing them, but I started getting Good at one thing a new task would then require time and effort once again to understand.

A valuable learning experience involved was processing Purchase Orders received from the City of Cape Town. This required capturing information such as Purchase Order numbers, received dates, project durations and scopes of work. here I was also required to update project statuses, calculate contractual completion dates and assist in generating supporting documentation such as Purchase Order Alerts and Letters of Appointment. These activities exposed me to the administrative processes that occur before physical work can commence and demonstrated the importance of maintaining accurate project records.

The concept of Letters of Appointment also became much clearer during the placement, I learned that Letters of Appointment are used to formally appoint subcontractors and define the scope of work they are responsible for undertaking. They also provide a contractual mechanism through which subcontractor

performance, claims and obligations can be managed throughout the duration of a project.

Another particularly valuable exercise involved comparing subcontractor quotations against H&I's tendered rates and Bills of Quantities. This process allowed me to observe how quantity surveyors and project managers assess subcontractor pricing before work is awarded. By identifying significant differences between subcontractor rates and approved tender rates, the team could determine whether pricing was reasonable or whether further clarification was required. This experience introduced me to the "commercial" side of construction and demonstrated how financial decisions are made before projects progress to site.

Throughout the placement, I worked closely with Senior quantity surveyors Ieliyaas Abderoef and Rodger Phillips. Observing their work provided valuable insight into the responsibilities of quantity surveyors within the construction industry. I witnessed how they measured quantities, reviewed costs, prepared pricing information and monitored financial aspects of projects. What stood out most was the level of accuracy required. Even relatively small errors in measurements, rates or quantities could have significant consequences for project costing and procurement decisions.

During the second vacation period, because I had no access to measuring software I was introduced to digital measurement software and tasked with undertaking quantity take-offs from construction drawings. These measurements included elements such as masonry walls, plasterwork, paintwork, concrete works and structural steel. At first, I found the process challenging because I was unfamiliar with the online software and measurement procedures. However, as I gained experience, I began to recognise the logical and systematic nature of measurement work.

One of the most important lessons I learned from this exercise was the relationship between quantities and project costs. Accurate measurements directly influence quotations, Purchase Orders, subcontractor payments and overall project budgets. During several exercises, I compared my measurements against those completed by Jayden, a junior Quantity surveyor and quickly realised how rushing through calculations often resulted in inaccuracies. This taught me the importance of patience, accuracy and attention to detail. The experience also reminded me of concepts covered in Measurement and Design Appraisal I, where accurate quantity measurement forms the basis of estimating and cost planning.

Perhaps the greatest lesson gained from this aspect of the practical training was the importance of attention to detail. Throughout the placement, I repeatedly encountered situations where small pieces of information had significant

consequences. Whether reviewing subcontractor quotations, processing Purchase Orders, updating workload planners or measuring quantities, accuracy was essential. I came to understand that construction professionals are trusted not simply because they possess technical knowledge, but because they are able to process information carefully, identify discrepancies and make informed decisions based on accurate data.

This exposure significantly broadened my understanding of quantity surveying and contract administration. It demonstrated that successful project delivery depends not only on technical construction knowledge but also on effective financial management, procurement control, accurate measurement and organised documentation systems.

2.5 Site Inspections, Defects Management and Practical Completion

While much of my practical training took place in the office, it was the site visits and inspections that I found really fruitful. These experiences showed me how project managers, quantity surveyors, and contractors actually put quality control and contract administration into practice. What surprised me most was how firmly the project managers stood their ground. When they were not happy with the work, they simply would not sign off on practical completion, regardless of the delay or the anger it caused the subcontractors. They stood firm and used the JBCC as the grounds for making their point. It was not personal, it was contractual. Another thing that struck me was their experience, almost like they had trained "eyes for it." They seemed to instinctively know what was missing and what I could not see. To me, the work often looked normal, but to them, there was a lot wrong. It made me realise that acceptable work depends on a trained eye rather than just a checklist, and that decisions made behind a desk ultimately shape what happens on site.

Two early visits taught me the same lesson from different angles. At Wallacedene in Kraaifontein, I joined Project Manager Alec Kanyerere to inspect a subcontractor's work on a steel-framed structure. Here we found poor welding, skew structural elements, and badly finished concrete column pads, the kind of defects I might have glanced past because of my inexperience. Alec did not glance past them. Watching him flag issues I would not have caught made me feel impressed and inspired. I remember thinking to myself that I wanted to gain that kind of experience and that I needed to work even harder at school to build that knowledge. It made me realise how much acceptable work depends on a trained eye rather than just a checklist.

A very valuable experience by far was sitting in on a practical completion inspection meeting at the Philippi East Fresh Produce Market. In the room were representatives from the City of Cape Town, the subcontractor, the facility manager, and a candidate Professional Quantity Surveyor, and they were all trying to agree on whether the outstanding snags and defects had been dealt with well enough to move forward. I went in expecting a technical checklist exercise. What I got instead was something closer to a negotiation. The conversation covered everything from galvanisation requirements to fencing installations and repair methods that might save time or money, but the real work in the room was the project manager holding the balance between the client's expectations, the contractor's constraints, and the subcontractor's obligations, all at once, without ever losing sight of what the contract actually required. It was the first time I understood that much of project management is not technical at all. It is translation between people who each have a different stake in the same outcome.

That meeting also gave me my first real look at the JBCC contract in action. I learned that defects picked up after practical completion can still need fixing during the defects liability period, and that retention funds exist precisely to enforce that. Until then, JBCC had only ever been a word I would hear here and there in class.

At Belroad Fire Station, my job was smaller. I photographed the completed subcontractor work and sent the images to the project manager for his reports. It felt almost too simple to count as real learning. But having the opportunity to access a fire station on behalf of the project manager made me take the task seriously. I found myself looking for defects, using the lessons I had learned from previous site visits, and I felt a sense of pride in being trusted with the responsibility.

Looking back, these visits changed how I understand the role of a project manager. I used to assume the job was mostly about issuing instructions and checking progress against a programme. But what I actually saw was something different. The job is built on the contract. It follows a clear method for how work should start and be completed. Seeing how communication, coordination, and constant small judgement calls actually play out on site gave me a new appreciation for the profession.

But if there is one thing that really stayed with me, it is what I learned about practical completion itself. I used to think it simply meant the construction work was done. I now understand it as a formal contractual milestone, one that is only reached once the workmanship meets the required standard, the defects have been resolved, and the client genuinely believes the facility is ready to be used. That distinction connected so much of what I had studied in Construction Management and Business Law. It is probably the single idea from this placement that I will carry with me furthest into my career.

2.6 Professional Growth, Personal Reflection and Linking Theory to Practice

While the technical knowledge and industry exposure gained during my practical training were extremely valuable, the most significant lessons I learned were personal rather than technical. Looking back on the experience, I can confidently say that my greatest area of growth was not in understanding contracts, measurements or Purchase Orders but actually in changing the way I approached learning and professional development.

When I first arrived at H&I, I experienced a great deal of anxiety. As a Construction Studies student and bursary recipient, I felt a strong sense of responsibility to perform well and justify the investment that H&I had made in my education. Unfortunately, I placed unrealistic expectations on myself. I believed that because I was studying construction at university, I should already possess a high level of competence around the workplace. As a result, I often felt uncomfortable asking questions because I feared appearing inexperienced or incapable.

This mindset quickly became one of the biggest obstacles to my learning. Whenever I encountered something I did not understand, I would spend excessive amounts of time trying to solve the problem independently. Rather than seeking clarification from colleagues, I would attempt to work through spreadsheets, measurements and project documentation on my own. In many cases this resulted in mistakes, inefficiencies and unnecessary stress. Looking back, I realise that I had unintentionally created a mental barrier between myself and the people who were trying to help me learn.

Over time, however, my perspective began to change. Through regular interactions with project managers, quantity surveyors and engineers, I came to realise that nobody expected me to know everything. In fact, my colleagues repeatedly encouraged me to ask questions and reminded me that practical training exists for the purpose of learning. As I became more comfortable seeking guidance, I found that my understanding improved significantly and my confidence grew alongside it.

One of the most important personal lessons I learned was that professional competence is not measured by knowing all the answers. Instead, it is demonstrated through a willingness to learn, ask questions, accept feedback and continuously improve. This lesson extended beyond construction and became something that I reflected on personally. For much of the placement, I found myself competing against unrealistic expectations that I had created for myself. Once I accepted that learning is a process rather than a test of perfection, I was able to enjoy the experience far more and benefit from the opportunities around me.

The difference between my first week and my final week at H&I was significant. During the early stages of the placement, I was hesitant to approach colleagues and often worried about making mistakes. By the end of the training period, I was actively requesting additional work, seeking feedback on completed tasks and engaging confidently with the professionals around me. I no longer viewed mistakes as failures but rather as opportunities to improve. This change in attitude allowed me to gain far more from the experience than I would have otherwise.

Another important outcome of the placement was seeing how university theory translates into professional practice. Throughout my time at H&I, I encountered numerous concepts that I had previously studied in lectures. Terms such as Bills of Materials, tender rates, Purchase Orders, contracts, practical completion, measurements and procurement procedures were no longer theoretical concepts found in notes and textbooks. Instead, they became real tools used daily by construction professionals to manage projects.

Several modules within the BSc Construction Studies programme were particularly relevant to the work I encountered. Concepts from Construction Management helped me understand project planning, communication structures and stakeholder relationships. Measurement and Design Appraisal provided a foundation for the quantity take-offs and measurement exercises I completed. Business Law assisted in understanding contractual obligations and procurement procedures, while quantity surveying principles became increasingly relevant through my exposure to costing, BOQs and subcontractor quotations.

One of the most rewarding aspects of the placement was experiencing the moment when classroom knowledge began to connect with industry practice. There were numerous occasions where documents, terminology and processes that I had previously encountered in lectures suddenly made sense because I was seeing them applied within real projects. This gave me a greater appreciation for the value of my university studies and reinforced the importance of the knowledge being developed throughout the degree programme.

The placement also broadened my understanding of the construction industry and the various professional roles within it. Prior to joining H&I, my understanding of construction was largely centred around site activities and physical construction work. Through exposure to project managers, quantity surveyors, engineers, health and safety officers, site agents and senior management personnel, I developed a much broader appreciation of the collaborative nature of the industry. I gained insight into how different professionals contribute to project success and how their responsibilities overlap throughout the project lifecycle.

Although this practical training did not fundamentally change my career aspirations, it significantly expanded my understanding of the opportunities available within the construction industry. The experience demonstrated that construction management involves far more than supervising site activities. It requires effective communication, leadership, financial awareness, problem solving and attention to detail. The placement confirmed my interest in the management side of construction while simultaneously exposing me to aspects of quantity surveying, contract administration and project coordination that I had not previously considered in depth.

If I were given the opportunity to repeat this practical training experience, there are several things I would do differently. Most importantly, I would ask questions earlier and more frequently. I would also take greater initiative in seeking exposure to different departments and continue developing my understanding of contract administration and digital construction management tools. Most importantly, I would avoid creating unnecessary pressure for myself by believing that I need to know everything before I begin. The experience taught me that growth comes from being willing to learn rather than pretending to already have all the answers.

Ultimately, the most valuable lesson I will take from H&I Construction is that professional development is a continuous process. Technical knowledge is important, but success within the construction industry also requires humility, communication, adaptability and a willingness to learn from those around you. This practical training not only improved my understanding of the construction industry but also contributed significantly to my growth as a future construction professional.

3. Conclusion

The practical training with H&I Construction provided a valuable opportunity to experience the construction industry from a perspective that differed significantly from my previous site-based work. Prior to joining H&I, my understanding of construction was largely centred around physical construction activities such as earthworks, paving and bricklaying. Through this placement, I was exposed to the managerial, contractual and administrative processes that support the successful delivery of construction projects.

The experience demonstrated that construction management extends far beyond activities taking place on site. Exposure to workload planners, Purchase Orders, Bills of Materials, subcontractor quotations, Letters of Appointment and project documentation highlighted the importance of planning, communication, procurement and contract administration. Site inspections further reinforced the

importance of quality control, stakeholder management and practical completion procedures in ensuring successful project outcomes.

The placement also enabled me to observe how knowledge gained through the BSc Construction Studies programme is applied within industry. Concepts previously encountered in modules such as Construction Management, Measurement and Design Appraisal, Quantity Surveying and Business Law became much clearer when observed in a professional environment. This strengthened my understanding of the relationship between academic learning and practical application.

From a personal perspective, the placement contributed significantly to my professional development. One of the most important lessons I learned was that professional growth is achieved through a willingness to learn, ask questions and accept feedback. At the start of the placement, I often placed unnecessary pressure on myself because I believed I should already possess a greater understanding of industry practices. As the training progressed, I became more comfortable seeking guidance from colleagues and embracing the learning opportunities available to me. This shift in mindset improved both my confidence and my ability to learn effectively.

The experience also broadened my understanding of the various professional roles within the construction industry. Working alongside project managers, quantity surveyors, engineers, site agents and health and safety personnel provided insight into the collaborative nature of construction projects and the contribution each discipline makes towards successful project delivery.

Overall, the practical training successfully achieved its objectives by exposing me to real construction projects, developing my professional skills and strengthening my understanding of industry practices. The knowledge, skills and experiences gained during the placement have provided a strong foundation for my future development and will undoubtedly contribute to my growth as a construction professional.

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5. AI Acknowledgement

Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools were used during the preparation of this report to assist with language refinement, editing, formatting and the organisation of ideas. All experiences, observations, reflections, technical information and conclusions presented in this report are based on the author's own practical training experience, personal reflections and supporting documentation obtained during the placement. The final content was reviewed, edited and verified by the author to ensure its accuracy and authenticity.